> When he had been consecrated eight years, the Beloved of the Gods, king Piyadassi, conquered Kalinga. A hundred and fifty thousand people were deported, a hundred thousand were killed, and many times that number perished [21] . Afterwards, now that Kalinga is annexed, the Beloved of Gods very earnestly practiced Dhamma, desired Dhamma, and taught Dhamma [22] . On conquering Kalinga the Beloved of the Gods felt remorse, for when an independent country is conquered the slaughter, death and deportation of the people is extremely grievous to the Beloved of Gods and weighs heavily on his mind …. Even those who were fortunate to have escaped and whose love is undiminished suffer from the misfortunes of their friends, acquaintances, colleagues and relatives. The participation of all men in suffering weighs heavily on the mind of the Beloved of the Gods'.
>
> —Major Edict XIII.
>
> Translated by Romila Thapar [23]

The Kalinga campaign was clearly brutal, with 150,000 deported, a direct death toll of 100,000 and even larger numbers dead from wounds and famine. India's population at this stage would have been around 65 million [24] and casualties on such a scale would have been devastating for a small province like Kalinga. Excavations at Kalinga's capital of Tosali reveal structures that still bear marks of a devastating assault. The large number of arrowheads found embedded in a small section of the ramparts tell of a blizzard of arrows. Ashoka appears to have regretted his decision because of the suffering it caused—very unusual for any era and in stark contrast to the brutal rule of the First Emperor of China at about the same time. Nonetheless, one should always take statements made by politicians with a pinch of salt. The edicts are, after all, what Ashoka wanted us to remember of him. Notice that Ashoka expresses regret but does not offer to free Kalinga and its inhabitants.

Although the inscriptions are very interesting, I think historians have focused too much attention on the noble sentiments expressed in them and not enough on the overall impact of the pillars. Around 40–50 feet high, the stone columns are impressive structures often capped by a lion (or lions), an animal that was associated with the Mauryas since Chandragupta's time. In some of the pillars, the lions are accompanied with the 'chakra' or wheel. Historians often associate this with the Buddhist 'dharma-chakra' but, in